



△ PRAYER HALL

Lines of columns divide the mosque's finely decorated, richly carpeted prayer hall into a series of parallel naves. Many of the columns were taken from earlier Roman and Byzantine buildings.

◁ HOLY CITY

The Great Mosque stands in the heart of Kairouan's medieval walled quarter. Kairouan is ranked as the fourth most sacred city of Islam, surpassed in holiness only by Mecca, Medina, and Jerusalem.

Great Mosque of Kairouan

The oldest mosque in Africa, which exhibits the decorative and architectural splendor of medieval Islamic civilization



The first mosque at Kairouan, Tunisia, was founded in 670 CE by Uqba ibn Nafi, one of the Arab warriors spreading the newly born Islamic faith by conquest across northern Africa. Although the current mosque is often referred to as the Uqba Mosque, its buildings date from the mid-9th century, when Kairouan flourished under the Aghlabid dynasty (800–909). The Aghlabids made the Great Mosque not only a place of worship but also a renowned center of learning.

Intricate decoration

From the outside, the mosque seems to be an austere building, dominated by its massive, three-tiered stone minaret. Inside its extensive prayer hall, however, austerity is replaced by exuberant decoration. The space is filled with marble, granite, and porphyry columns. The wooden ceiling is painted with elaborate designs; the *minbar* (pulpit) is finely carved in Indian teak; and the *mihrab*, the focus of prayer, is an elaborate display of marble and tilework. By the 11th century, Kairouan had gone into decline, but the mosque has remained one of the most sacred places in the Islamic world.

IMPOSING STRUCTURE

The mosque covers an area of more than 116,000 square ft (10,800 square m). The towering minaret, 105 ft (32 m) high, is mounted by a staircase of 129 steps. The vast inner courtyard, surrounded by an arcade of horseshoe-shaped arches and columns, has six side entrances. The entire building has about 500 columns, most of them in the prayer hall.

